

THE REVOLUTIONARY PRACTICE of

*Black
Feminism*

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I think something that had made me advocate for myself as a black woman for is the mistreatment I have experienced from my professors coming into college as a freshman. During grade school, I experienced colorism and racism firsthand, and other people of color being treated differently (specifically by white professors) because of our complexion. Being forced to do certain things, white students didn't (such as harder assignments, or being told to leave the classroom, when all I was doing as quietly sitting down and doing my work), or being targeted by professors when I wasn't doing anything wrong. Especially living with undiagnosed ADHD, growing up it initially was hard for me to understand why I was being treated so poorly. Now, being in college, I have understood that it is okay to speak out, and fight back against professors who push a racist rhetoric in their classrooms. I have begun to respectfully respond to them, and stand my ground instead of being pushed over.

- GWEN MILLER,

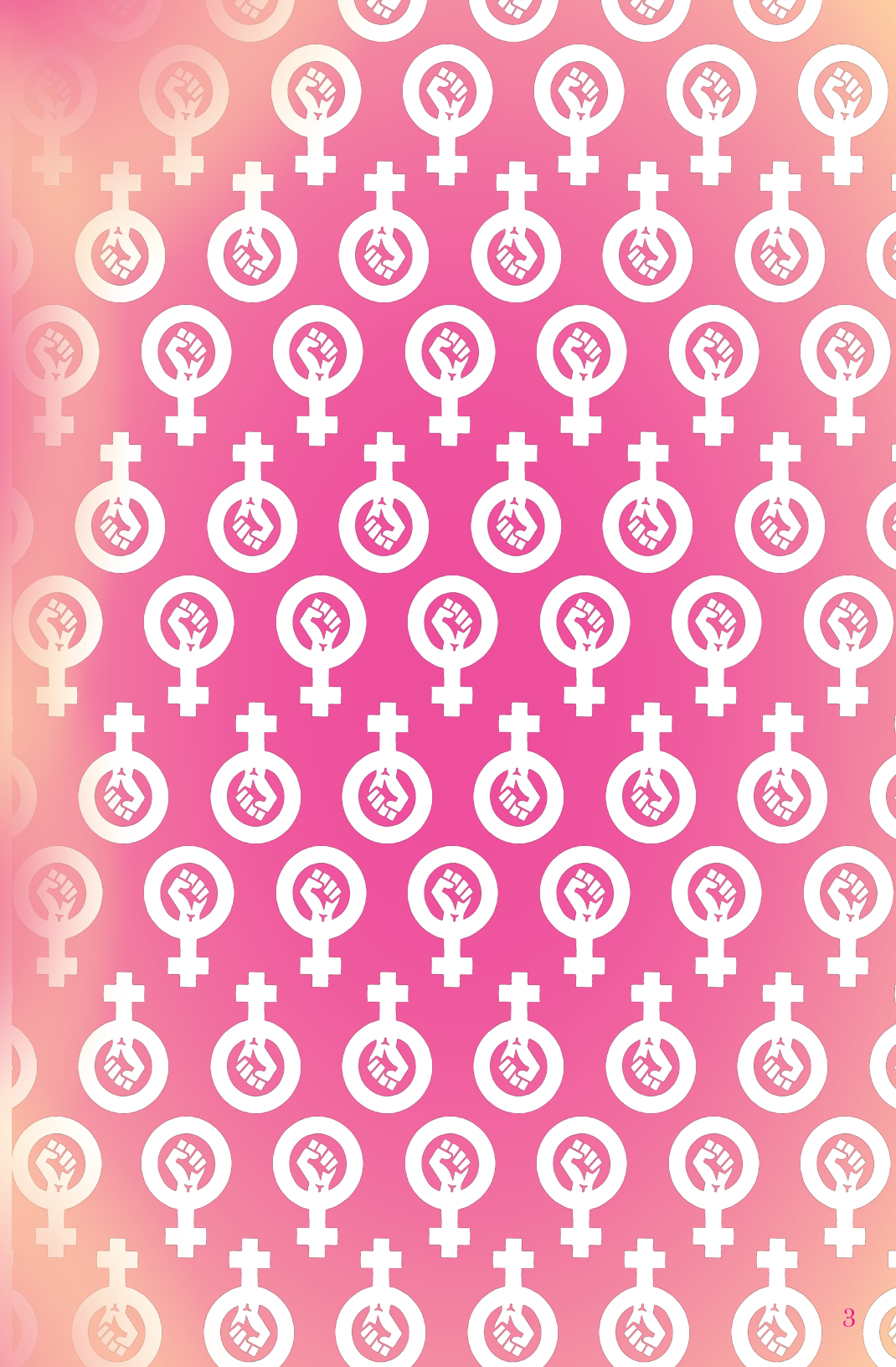
A Black Feminist



An experience that shapes me as a Black feminist is navigating colorism while trying to find my place as an artist. As a lighter-skinned Black woman, I notice how differently I'm treated—sometimes given more visibility, yet still feeling misunderstood or not fully seen. That tension has made me think deeply about belonging, identity, and who gets to take up space.

As an artist, I've also felt pressure to fit into certain expectations of what Black art should be, which can make it feel like there isn't space for more complex or personal expressions. Because of this, I'm driven to advocate for myself and other Black women by recognizing our different experiences and creating work that makes room for more voices, stories, and perspectives.

- GABBY,
A Black Feminist



One of the main ways I really got into Black feminism was during my Gender, Sexuality, and Women's studies class during freshman year. That class discussed misogyny pretty often, and I usually focused my assignments on Black women. I remember that one of my assignments was about the recent passing of Krystal Anderson, a Chiefs cheerleader and software engineer, who died during childbirth. That story really got me into researching the Black maternal mortality rate, and how mainstream feminism needs to really emphasize just how fucked up it is!! The way Black mothers are treated is utterly insane to me, and can make me pretty emotional, but I tend to find comfort in how Black feminism discusses this lack of care. Black feminism over all is just so freeing in how it acknowledges and calls out the stereotypes pushed onto Black women, in a way that I never really see done by white feminists.

- IMANI,

A Black Feminist

One experience that shaped why I identify as a Black feminist isn't just one moment but a pattern I've noticed over time. In spaces like school and work, I've seen how Black women are expected to always be strong and accommodating, while our feelings or contributions can get overlooked. That's what made me more aware of how race and gender intersect in everyday life. At the same time, seeing Black women uplift each other and create spaces where we can just be ourselves reinforced that identity for me. Those experiences are a big part of why I see myself as a Black feminist.

- NADIA,

A Black Feminist

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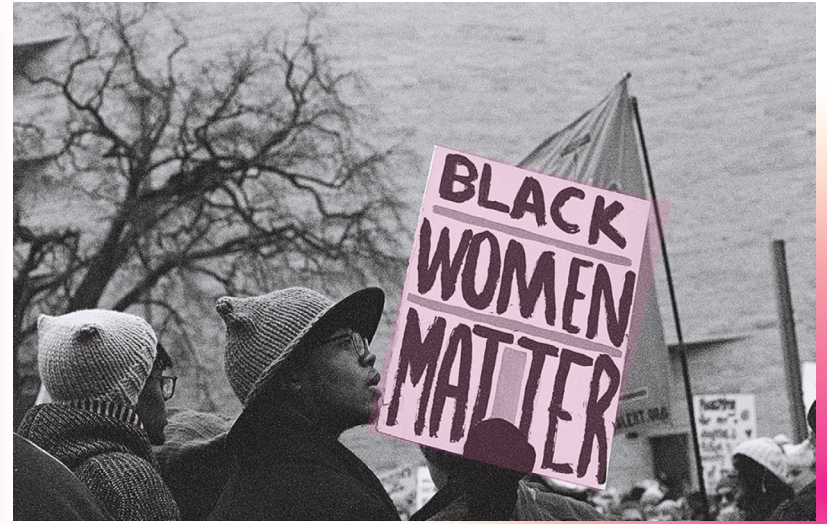
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- A Black Feminist

Although not my own, the story of Weyzero Mulumebet Emiru is one that has always made me proud to be black woman. There is not much known about Weyzero Mulumebet but from what was documented hers is a story of sheer bravery and excellence. In the 1930s, in a world dominated by men, and a career field dominated by men, Weyzero Mulumebet decided she wanted to be a pilot. In 1934 through courage, determination, and persistence Weyzero Mulumebet would complete her training and receive her license making her Africa's first woman pilot. Unfortunately her piloting career was cut short due to war but that did not stop Emperor Haile Selassie of Ethiopia from taking notice of her accomplishments and awarding her with land. Weyzero Mulumebet then took that land and cultivated coffee beans on it and created a coffee empire that is run by her family today. I believe Weyzero Mulumebet to be a black feminist because during a time period where women were still considered property of their fathers/husbands she decided to defy all odds and not only follow her dreams but to make them come true.

LISTEN TO *Her*



In 1864, Sojourner Truth sold cartes-de-visite, small photographs mounted to a paper card, to support her activism. Featuring the slogan “I sell the shadow to support the substance,” Truth capitalized on the popularity of these collector’s items to support herself and fund her speaking tours. As a formerly enslaved person, claiming ownership of her image for her own profit was revolutionary. Truth reportedly said that she “used to be sold for other people’s benefit, but now she sold herself for her own.”

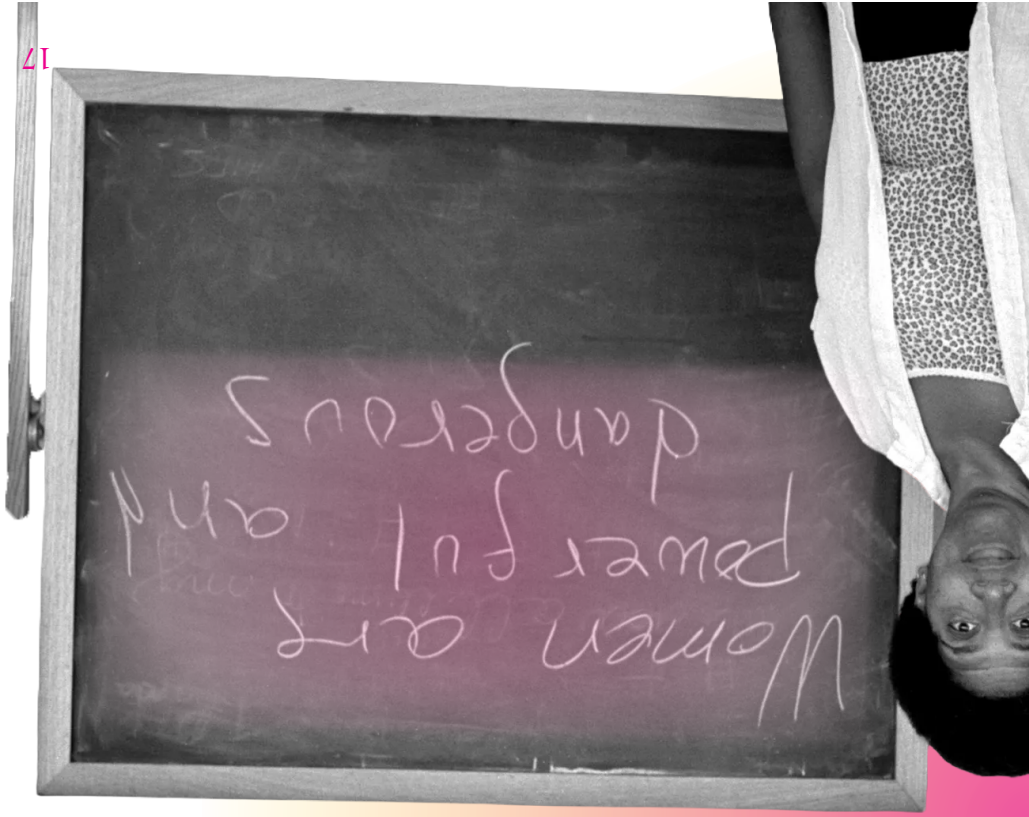
Though expressions of black feminism can be seen in written accounts as far back as the 1830s, Sojourner Truth is the most widely known nineteenth-century black feminist foremother. Throughout her life, Truth linked the movement to abolish slavery and the movement to secure women’s rights, stating that for black women, race and gender could not be separated. Truth’s speeches and activism represent an early expression of the black feminist tradition.

Black feminism is an intellectual, artistic, philosophical, and activist practice grounded in black women's lived experiences. Its scope is broad, making it difficult to define. In fact, the diversity of opinion among black feminists makes it more accurate to think of black feminisms in the plural. In an oral history interview from the Museum's collection, noted activist and scholar

Angela Davis SPEAKS TO THIS POINT:



While late nineteenth century black feminisms were grounded in heterosexual black women's bodies, by the end of the twentieth and into the twenty-first century, radical black feminisms came to center queer and trans black women, girls, and gender nonconforming people. Outside black feminist circles, black feminisms are often described as an outgrowth of other freedom struggles. While black women's experiences working within political and social movements of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries certainly informed articulations of black feminism, black feminisms have never been derivative, nor do they fit cleanly into the "waves" of feminist history. For black women and other women of color, race and gender are inseparable, and black feminists resist all movements that ignore this reality. From women's suffrage to the Women's March of 2017, they have been unwilling to compromise on the assertion that a feminism which does not incorporate different experiences of womanhood cannot achieve full liberation. Since before Sojourner Truth sold her "shadow," women in the black feminist tradition have developed theoretical frameworks and practices born of their experiences, to get, as black feminist scholar Dr. Treva Lindsey put it, "freer and freer and freer."



The 1970s marked an increase in explicitly black feminist organizing, due in part to tensions inflamed during the Women's Liberation and Civil Rights Movements. By this time, queer black feminists were becoming more openly and visibly positioned within black feminist groups. They also began creating their own organizations—such as the Salsa Soul Sisters, one of the first out and explicitly multi-cultural lesbian organizations—due to tensions with straight black feminists as well as white gays and lesbians. The influential Combahee River Collective statement, co-authored by Barbara Smith, expressed a radical, queer black feminist platform still relevant to expressions of black feminism today. In 1983, Alice Walker developed the term **womanist** to describe “a Black feminist or feminist of color.” Her term defined a more communal and humanist expression of feminism that acknowledged

queer black women and aligned with long-standing traditions of black women's thought and activism. *Sister Outsider*, by Audre Lorde, is one of many foundational womanist writings produced during this period. In her essays and speeches, Lorde discusses the connected issues of sexism, racism, classism, and heterosexism, while calling for new tactics that centered these intersections. Black women are often thought to be at a disadvantage because of racism and sexism, but some black feminists view their position as one of possibility. They argue that in the struggle for freedom, the people most exposed to different forms of oppression understand best how to dismantle them.

“I RARELY TALK ABOUT FEMINISM IN THE SINGULAR. I TALK ABOUT FEMINISMS. AND, EVEN WHEN I MYSELF REFUSED TO IDENTIFY WITH FEMINISM, I REALIZED THAT IT WAS A CERTAIN KIND OF FEMINISM . . . IT WAS A FEMINISM OF THOSE WOMEN WHO WEREN'T REALLY CONCERNED WITH EQUALITY FOR ALL WOMEN...”

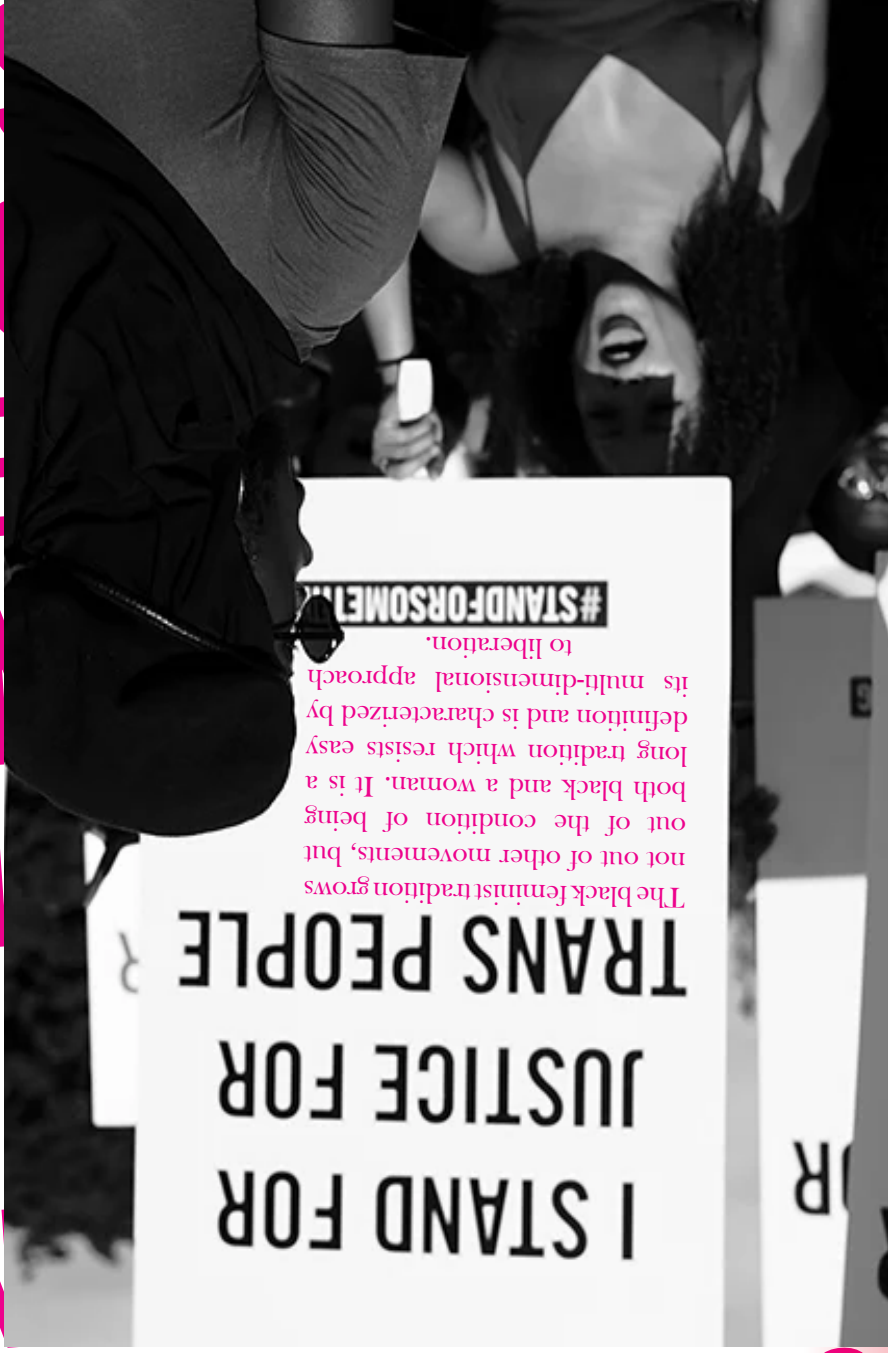
Dr. Angela Davis

August 5th, 2019, Oral History Interview,
National Museum of African American History and Culture

Despite different visions, a few foundational principles do exist among black feminists:

Black women's experience of racism, sexism, and classism are inseparable. Their needs and worldviews are distinct from those of black men and white women.

"Lifting as we climb," the slogan of the National Association of Colored Women (NACW), became a well-known motto for black women's activism in the late nineteenth century. By this time, middle class black women organized social and political reform through women's organizations, or clubs.



As the only female student at Howard University Law School, Pauli Murray developed the term Jane Crow, the “twin evil of Jim Crow,” to describe the sexism black women faced. She would continue to develop theoretical, legal, and political frameworks for describing black women’s experiences. Her legal work connecting race-based and sex-based discrimination led to the inclusion of sex-based discrimination under the Equal Protection Clause. However, due to the Civil Rights Movement’s demands for “respectable” performances of black womanhood, Murray’s many contributions to civil rights history remain relatively unknown. Despite this neglect of her work, the legal and theoretical parallels she drew between racial discrimination and gender discrimination set the stage for feminist thinkers to follow.

Having had more resources and access to education than a woman like Sojourner Truth, these women's experiences led them to a different expression of black feminism. Their project of racial uplift focused on combating harmful stereotypes surrounding black women's sexuality and gender identity. Problematically, they emphasized elevating poor women, less out of a sense of good-will, than out of a recognition that black women of any class would be judged through the circumstances of those "with the fewest resources and the least opportunity."

*"with the fewest resources
and the least opportunity."*

In discussing the motto of the NACW, Mary Church Terrell, founding president of the organization, said,

*"Even though we wish to shun them...
we cannot escape the consequences of
their acts... Self-preservation would
demand that we go among the lowly...
to whom we are bound by ties of race
and sex."*

The black feminism of the club movement is often overlooked, but as black feminist theorist Brittney Cooper points out, clubs such as the NACW can be seen as sites of development for black feminist leadership and thought despite their elitism. The club movement ushered in a new era of intellectual, artistic, and philosophical production by black women about their own experiences. Pauli Murray, an activist, writer, Episcopal priest, and legal scholar, played an important role in several civil, social, and legal organizations including the National Organization of Women (NOW), which she cofounded in 1966. Throughout her life, Murray had romantic relationships with women but did not consider herself a lesbian. Her biographer, Rosalind Rosenberg, suggests that had Murray been alive today, she likely would have embraced a transgender identity. Murray wrote and theorized extensively on her experiences of black womanhood asserting that, for her, gender, race, and sexuality could not be separated. This refusal to separate her identity fueled her legal work and activism.

